



LOWLAND HEATHS

In milder climates, rainwater seeping down through fast-draining sand or gravel carries away dissolved nutrients to create thin, acidic soils, much like moorland soil. The effect on plants is similar, forming low-growing, heather-dominated landscapes called heaths. But the warmer climate allows a wider variety of plants to grow, and heaths attract reptiles including lizards and snakes, as well as insects such as dragonflies and butterflies.

▲ SUMMER FLOWERS

This coastal heath is bright with the flowers of yellow gorse and different types of heather.



KILLER PLANTS

Plant nutrients, particularly nitrates, are scarce on peat bogs. Some plants get around this by catching insects and digesting them to extract their nitrogen. This Venus flytrap has leaves that snap shut on insects that land on them and brush against their tiny trigger hairs. Pitcher plants drown their insect prey in pools of digestive fluid.



ARID SCRUB

Scrub made up of low-lying bushes and plants is the natural vegetation of many warm, dry regions. It has different names in different parts of the world—South African fynbos, California chaparral, Mediterranean maquis, and Australian mallee. The pincushion protea seen here being visited by a nectar-feeding sunbird is a fynbos plant.

FIRE!

We think of fire as destructive, but natural fires are a key feature of heathlands and arid scrub. In many of these habitats, fire triggers the release and growth of seeds from certain specialized plants. It also destroys trees and other plants that compete with the new seedlings for space. The heathland plants rely on fire for their survival—and without it, these habitats would simply disappear.

